



North Head Sanctuary Foundation Inc

Custodians of North Head

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Newsletter No 203 Sept-Oct 2026

Spring has sprung!

Judy Lambert

Spring flowering began early this year and North Head certainly put on a show for our annual Spring wildflower walks.

Most sessions were fully booked for the 3 walks held to date, with one more scheduled on 4 October. Volunteer leaders, Peter Macinnis and Christy Watson, provided a wealth of information to visitors on these 2-2½ hour strolls covering to the Hanging Swamp, the Third Quarantine Cemetery, and the main tracks between Bandicoot Heaven at the former School of Artillery and the Harbour Trust's Visitor Centre at North Fort. Lynette Jones also played a key role keeping the groups together.

Peter and Christy also lent their support to the Harbour Trust's Discovery Day spring walks which were also fully subscribed.

Visitors were keen to see the native orchids along the way, and several species obliged - Flying Ducks, Sun orchids, Beard orchids, Tiger orchids, Onion orchids, both Pink and White Fingers, the Climbing orchid and the somewhat elusive Pixie Caps (the Latin name of which, *Acianthus fornicatus*) attracts attention.

The abundance of other heathland species found at North Head were also a highlight for many, including the keen photographers who joined us.



Boronias are now on show off the bike track leading to the cemetery.
Photo; Peter Macinnis

Nesting lapwings (*Vanellus miles*)

Peter Macinnis

Lapwings are often called plovers - Australia has 16 plover species - but ours is the masked lapwing.

These lapwings make their nests on open ground,

usually laying four eggs about the size of a hen's egg. Nesting birds will leave their eggs to lure people and predators away, while making very noisy threats and displays.



Photos: Peter Macinnis

Birders say the birds nest on open ground so as to see predators coming. Volunteers and rangers also mark out the nests with traffic cones or logs to help protect the eggs. If predators get too close, the lapwings will emit a danger call, and start low swoops. If you see and hear this behaviour, please move back outside the markers, which show what they consider a safe distance.

The nest sites are used year after year, and it appears that the same couples show up, around late July, and start laying a week or two later. One parent will normally sit on the eggs while the other is feeding nearby. They will live like this for the best part of four weeks until all the chicks hatch, around early September.



L-R (top) *Actinotus*, *Styphelia*. L-R (below) *Flying Duck* and *Bootlace* orchids
Photos; Peter Macinnis



Photos: Peter Macinnis

The birds appear to eat insects - I have seen adults feast on an ant swarm, and no doubt the chicks do the same. At all times, the parents communicate with a series of calls, most of them relating to danger. One harsh **kek** tells the chicks to drop, and when they do, they merge into the ground. That said, usually two or more chicks are soon lost.

If all the chicks die (kookaburras and cars are major predators), the adults will often try a second clutch, but nature's grim calculus usually holds sway. If the 'scrape' stays empty, we put the markers away when they leave, holding them till next year.

Third Quarantine Cemetery – Dorothy Erickson

Kaye Lee

A brief mention in Carmel Kelleher's excellent thesis on the North Head Quarantine Station⁽¹⁾ reveals that a burial took place in the cemetery in the summer of 1921, that of the Station Gatekeeper's daughter Dolly - Dorothy Sunniva Erickson - who died on 24 February 1921 and was buried two days later.

What is unusual about this fact is that Dolly's death and burial is not recorded in the Records of Deaths at the Quarantine Station⁽²⁾, unlike the more than 240 people whose deaths were meticulously recorded by Quarantine staff. Her death certificate would seem to provide the reason for this.

Dolly, the eldest child of Edvard (later Edward) and Annie Erickson, died, not in the Quarantine hospital facilities, but in a cottage at the Quarantine Station⁽³⁾. She had been sick for eleven months, suffering from phthisis (tuberculosis), and treated by local doctor, R B Minnett. She was 22 at the time, unmarried and had been employed as a packer.

Dolly and her siblings, Arthur (Jim) and Regina, had grown up at the Quarantine Station - it was their home. Dolly's father Edward was employed there as an Assistant from 1903 until 1914, then Gatekeeper (as was his wife at times) until 1928⁽⁴⁾. He lived in the Gatekeeper's cottage with his family, where Dolly was cared for and died.



Dorothy (Dolly) Sunniva Erickson

Where though is Dolly's grave? There is no headstone or memorial to assist in identifying it. Kelleher suggests it might be in the Second Cemetery, but considered unlikely as it had not been used for 40 years. The Third Cemetery, however, had been in use from 1881 right up until 1925.

Dolly's interment would have been the second last in the Third Cemetery, the burial immediately before hers being that of Pat Martinson in 1919 and the last, Samain in August 1925⁽⁵⁾. Both are believed to be buried in the eastern section of the cemetery, as others whose deaths closely preceded theirs are known to be buried there. There is one visible grave in this area however, that remains a mystery, the occupant unknown. Could that be Dolly's final resting place?



Unknown grave Photo: Kaye Lee

No proof of this has yet been found, but it could quite possibly be Dolly's grave. Martinson, and the crew members of the SS St. George and Pacificque whose burials also preceded hers, were all seafarers, their graves identified by simple wooden markers. Dolly however was one of the 'Quarantine family' and more likely to have been given a more formal grave setting by family and friends.

1. Kelleher CP Quarantine Station North Head 1900-1984: A history of place 2014
2. Record of Deaths at the Quarantine Station NAA:526
3. Dorothy Sunneva Erickson Death Certificate 3453/1921 NSW B.D.M. (spelling of Sunniva different to B.D.M. birth registration)
4. Kelleher CP Quarantine Station North Head 1900-1984: A history of place 2014 p.202, 210
5. NAA:526 Record of Deaths at the Quarantine Station Screen p.70

*Many thanks to Ross Erickson for permission to use the photo of Dolly.

The Passing of a Master Craftsman

Peter Nash

Sadly, one of the familiar faces at North Head, **Jim Frecklington** has passed away. Early on in his career Jim was the caretaker of the royal stables and was well respected for his knowledge of horses and carriages.

While we have been at North Head, he designed and created three horse drawn carriages, two for Queen Elizabeth in which both she and King Charles and Queen Camilla have ridden, with the third being intended for Prince Charles' coronation but which is only now being finished. He also restored an 18 pounder artillery gun complete with gun carriage for the ANZAC centenary.

Much has been written about Jim being a master craftsman but part of his talent was a knowledge of other people's talents which he was able to draw upon when creating his projects. An example of one such artisan is fine art painter Paula Church, whom some of us have met and who was responsible for the gilding of parts of the coaches, such as the coats of arms, with gold leaf. Jim was generous with his time and groups of us were able to see the latter two carriages up close and, on one occasion, I had a landscaper friend from California visiting and Jim, not a man of few words, kindly gave her a talk about the second coach together with an illustrated booklet about it. He was a friendly person who appreciated our interest in what he was doing and when driving past at North Fort or on Scenic Drive where we were working, always stopped to say hello and compliment us on the work we were doing. Jim was one of a kind who will be missed by all those who have met him.